

Kin is King

A third of the Cabinet is from the Badal family

- **PARKASH SINGH BADAL:** Chief minister and patron of SAD
- **SUKHBIR SINGH BADAL:** Badal's son, deputy chief minister and president of SAD.
- **MANPREET SINGH BADAL:** Badal's nephew and finance minister
- **ADESH PARTAP SINGH KAIRON:** Badal's son and food supplies minister
- **BIKRAM SINGH MAJITHIA:** Sukhbir's brother-in-law and patron of SAD's youth wing
- **JANMEJA SINGH JOHL:** Badal's close kin and irrigation minister



(LEFT) BADAL AND SUKHBIR; BJP LEADERS WITH RAJNATH SINGH

tory of their coalition governments that the SAD, with a strength of 47 MLAs, is dependent on the BJP's prop of 19 legislatures to stay in power in the 117-member Assembly.

The rancour was evident at Sukhbir's high-profile oath-taking function at Amritsar on January 21, attended by the BJP top brass not as much to bless the crown prince, but to project the façade of coalition unity despite a glaring rift. The sullen faces of the state BJP leaders including senior ministers, who showed up only after the central leadership issued a verbal fiat, betrayed the bad blood. Though senior party leader L.K. Advani and party President Rajnath Singh tried to mollify enraged state BJP leaders on the ground that senior Badal had kept them in the loop, they were far from satisfied. "Sukhbir's appointment is a political blunder and the state BJP rank and file has not reconciled to it," veteran BJP leader Balramji Dass Tandon told INDIA TODAY.

In the state BJP leaders' reckoning, denial of the deputy chief minister-ship to the junior coalition partner has upset the communal equilibrium in power sharing and sent a wrong signal to its support base in urban Hindu constituency which forms roughly 40 per cent of the state electorate.

Known to be an Akali in a hurry,

Dynasty Rules

Other political families

FAROOQ ABDULLAH (father)
Omar (son)

DEVI LAL (father)
Om Prakash Chautala (son)

H.D. DEVE GOWDA (father)
H.D. Kumaraswamy (son)

LALU YADAV (husband)
Rabri Devi (wife)

M. KARUNANIDHI (father)
M.K. Stalin (son)

the junior Badal had rapidly emerged as prime mover both in the party and the Government with the Opposition calling him "an extra constitutional centre of power". Sukhbir's new assignment is also an outcome of the power struggle in the Badal family. The patriarch has been under pressure from his wife Surinder Kaur and an assertive and ambitious daughter-in-law Harsimrat Kaur to make way for Sukhbir. A rather reluctant Badal, as his close aides reveal, was "wary of being jobless" if he handed over the mantle to his son. After the BJP's none-too-impressive performance in the recent Assembly elections, Badal had a change of heart and agreed to make Sukhbir his deputy.

When senior Akali leader and Cooperation Minister Captain Kanwaljit Singh suggested that the ensuing Lok Sabha elections would be the real test for Sukhbir's leadership, it evoked howls of protests from the Sukhbir protégés, forcing him to make amends. First off the starting blocks, the SAD has announced seven of its 10 candidates for the general elections. Having made the development card its main plank, the SAD hopes that Sukhbir's new status would galvanise the party rank and file.

Sukhbir is seen as the only counterfoil to former chief minister Amarinder Singh, who is aggressively spearheading the Congress challenge. In fact, Amarinder's recent roadshow that drew good response across the state had unnerved the SAD, prompting Badal to launch a month-long statewide tour. But as a SAD minister says, "There is too little time to bolster the party's electoral fortunes." In fact, Sukhbir's new role has given fresh ammunition to the Congress and the splinter Akali factions to target Badal for "turning the party into a family affair". "Only the Badals have progressed," says state PCC chief Mohinder Singh Kaypee. With the state BJP sulking and seething with anger, Badal's move to put his son a step closer to top post could well turn out to be a risky gambit. ■